



Migration Patterns in Southeastern North Carolina: 2018–2022

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Residents of Brunswick, New Hanover, and Pender Counties move frequently within and outside the region, and these movements shape local housing demand, commuting patterns, and community growth. While county-level population counts offer a useful starting point, they often obscure important differences across ZIP codes. To better capture these internal shifts, this brief uses ZIP-level migration flow data derived from the U.S. Postal Service’s Change-of-Address (COA) records to measure how people relocate within the area.

These data capture moves where households formally submit address changes, meaning short-term moves or informal relocations may not be fully represented.

The analysis focuses on three key indicators:

- (1) inflow, or the number of residents moving into a ZIP code from elsewhere,
- (2) outflow, or the number leaving for another ZIP code, and
- (3) net flow, which captures the difference between these movements.

Because the USPS data vary in completeness across years, the brief examines December flows, as December is the one month available across nearly all years. While this ensures consistency, it may not fully capture seasonal migration patterns, and results should therefore be interpreted as representative snapshots rather than full annual measures.

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How Net Migration Aligns with Population Change

Before turning to ZIP-code patterns, Table 1 compares COA flows with overall population change.

Table 1: Net Change-of-Address Flows and Share of Population Change, 2020–2022

Year	County	Pop. Change	COA Share (%)
2020	Brunswick	–	–
2021	Brunswick	6,584	87.7
2022	Brunswick	7,800	68.1
2020	New Hanover	–	–
2021	New Hanover	3,718	22.4
2022	New Hanover	5,898	5.9
2020	Pender	–	–
2021	Pender	2,360	63.0
2022	Pender	2,664	56.9

In Brunswick County, change-of-address flows closely match population change measured by the census. Because COA captures address-forwarding activity rather than all demographic components of change, this alignment indicates that migration, rather than natural growth, is the primary driver of population increases during this period.

Pender County shows a comparable pattern on a smaller scale, with migration accounting for a majority of population change. In contrast, New Hanover County shows a significant divergence between census population change and COA data. This discrepancy may reflect differences in housing dynamics, including rental turnover, student populations, or moves that are less likely to be captured through formal address-change filings.

How Do Annual Migration Patterns Differ Across Counties?

Net migration per 1,000 residents provides a consistent way to compare migration activity across counties of different sizes. This scaling allows for direct comparison but also introduces greater volatility in smaller populations, where even modest changes translate into larger proportional shifts.

Table 2: Net Internal Migration per 1,000 Residents, 2020–2022

Year	Brunswick	Pender
2020	44	22
2021	42	24
2022	39	25

Brunswick County recorded the highest sustained migration rates. These inflows are consistent with broader regional trends, including demand for coastal amenities and retirement migration.

Pender County also experienced steady increases, though at lower levels than Brunswick, with gains becoming more pronounced after 2020.

ZIP-Code Migration Patterns

County averages mask important spatial differences, even within relatively small geographic areas, making it difficult to identify where population growth is actually occurring. To examine how these patterns vary across communities, this section looks at migration flows at the ZIP-code level.

1. Brunswick

ZIP-level patterns show that migration gains are concentrated in southern coastal areas rather than spread evenly across the county. These areas align with higher amenity values and recent development activity, reinforcing their role as consistent in-migration destinations.

Southern coastal ZIP codes such as 28469 and 28468 recorded the highest rates and show sustained inflows across all years. In contrast, inland and northern ZIP codes display more variability, with some experiencing net losses in earlier years followed by partial recovery.

It is important to note that the same increase in population across ZIP codes of different sizes results in mechanically larger proportional changes in smaller ZIP codes. As a result, migration rates per 1,000 residents tend to appear more volatile in less populated areas, even when underlying movement is similar.

2. Pender

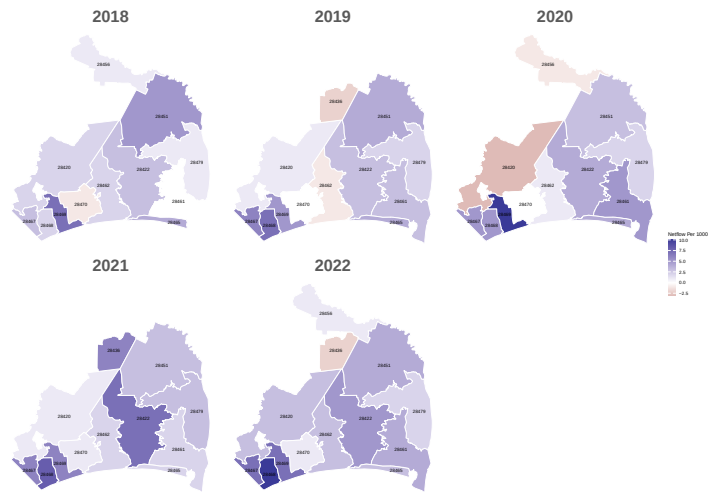


Figure 1: Migration Concentration in Brunswick County, 2018–2022

Pender County shows a shift from dispersed movement patterns to more concentrated migration activity over time. This transition coincides with post-2020 migration shifts observed nationally, including increased demand for lower-density and more affordable housing outside core metropolitan areas.

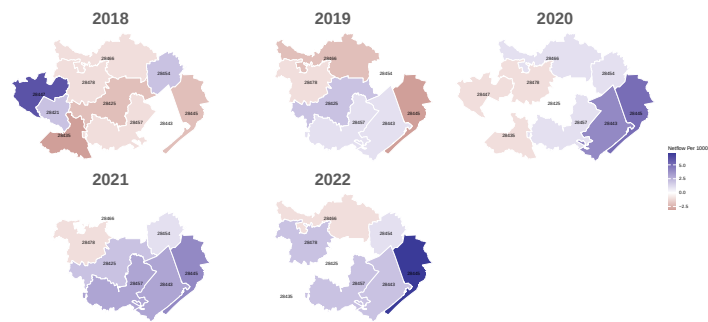


Figure 2: Migration Concentration in Pender County, 2018–2022

In earlier years, the county shows no persistent migration hotspots. By contrast, later years exhibit clear spatial concentration, particularly in eastern ZIP codes closer to coastal areas and commuting corridors. This indicates a shift toward more geographically focused population growth driven by a subset of communities.

Why Does Any of This Matter?

Migration patterns help explain why housing pressures differ across nearby communities. As shown in the ZIP-level maps, growth is not evenly distributed but concentrated, meaning local housing markets respond differently even within the same county.

When population growth concentrates in specific ZIP codes, housing demand can rise rapidly. This creates localized shortages that may not be immediately visible in county-level statistics, while infrastructure pressures also tend to emerge unevenly.

This mismatch complicates planning decisions, as infrastructure investments are often guided by broader population metrics rather than localized demand patterns.

Housing markets are particularly sensitive to these dynamics. Coastal and high-demand ZIP codes may experience rapid price increases, while nearby inland areas remain relatively stable despite their proximity. These differences illustrate why county-level trends alone are insufficient for understanding local growth patterns and why ZIP-level analysis provides a clearer lens for identifying where housing and infrastructure pressures are likely to emerge.